Production playbook

How I run a small-studio pipeline for casual and hybrid-puzzle titles.

Sector: Game production

Status: concept study, written and designed by Karthik Bindumon, 2026. Numbers are targets or modelled assumptions and are labelled as such.

Method: The Realisation Loop, v1 (see 00-realisation-loop.pdf).

How I run a small studio pipeline for casual and hybrid-puzzle titles. Thresholds are my rules of thumb and move by genre and market; the structure does not.

1 Roles and cadence

One producer, one design lead, one art lead, one video and creative lead, engineers by project. Weekly: a written status from each lead, read by all, no status meeting. Daily: a fifteen-minute stand-up for blockers only. Monthly: one portfolio review with the numbers, where prototypes are killed or funded.

2 The pipeline

Stage	Length	Exit rule
Concept	One page, one day	Hook can be said in one sentence and drawn in one frame.
Prototype	Two weeks	Core loop playable; first session under three minutes to the hook.
Gate: creative test	One week	Three video hooks and one playable in market; CPI read against the genre threshold.
Soft launch	Four to six weeks, one market	Day-1 and day-7 retention against threshold; economy dials exposed to live-ops.
Gate: scale or kill	One meeting	Numbers decide. Taste is argued before the gate, never at it.

3 Thresholds, rules of thumb

Hybrid-puzzle, casual, tier-2 market soft launch: CPI at or under $1.50, day-1 retention at or above 40 percent, day-7 at or above 15 percent. Above CPI and below retention: kill. Good CPI, weak retention: fix the first session, freeze creatives. Weak CPI, good retention: iterate creatives for two weeks; the build is fine.

4 The creative loop

Creatives run ahead of content. A creative brief is a beat sheet: three beats, one choice, one hook frame, under fifteen seconds. Editors and artists never receive a paragraph. Every creative gets a kill date on the day it ships.

5 Killing well

A killed prototype gets a one-page post-mortem within the week: the hypothesis, the number that failed, what we would do differently. The team moves the same week. A dead prototype with a clear post-mortem is an asset; a zombie project is a cost nobody books.

6 What I protect

Two-week prototypes are two weeks. No feature enters a soft launch without a dial for live-ops. Juniors ship something small in their first month with a buddy, on the Kata model.